The Hospital-to-Home Care Checklist

What to ask, gather and write down before Mom leaves the hospital or rehab.

Mom is in the hospital or rehab, discharge is being discussed, and everyone is asking you what happens next. Before that conversation, make sure you have these in hand. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something to ask for this week, not a verdict about Mom or about you.

Gather

- [ ] The discharge plan, or whatever discharge papers you've been given so far, in writing. [1]
- [ ] Mom's current medication list, with anything started, stopped or changed during this stay marked. [1]
- [ ] The names, roles and phone numbers of the people involved: the discharge planner or social worker, the doctor, the therapists, the business office.
- [ ] Every date you've been given, with who gave it to you. Mark a date you only heard second-hand as “not confirmed.”

Write down

- [ ] What changed: why Mom went into the hospital, the diagnoses you've been told, and what is different from a month ago, in your own words.
- [ ] What you've seen her do this week and where the staff help: bathing, dressing, eating, using the toilet, getting in and out of bed, walking. [1]
- [ ] What you've noticed about her memory, and about how she manages when no one is with her, written as what you saw.
- [ ] Anything about her safety that worries you, here or at home, so you can raise it with the care team.
- [ ] Who in the family can help, with what and on which days, and who is making healthcare decisions with Mom or for her.

Ask

- [ ] The expected discharge date, and what has to happen before it.
- [ ] What care the team expects Mom to need after she leaves, and whether any equipment is being recommended.
- [ ] Where that care could be provided, at home with help or in a facility, and who helps your family look at the options.
- [ ] Whether Medicare is covering Mom's care where she is now, and whether and when that may change. [1]
- [ ] Who can go over the costs with you: what your family may be asked to pay for, and who to talk to about it. [1]

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you gather, write down and ask. It doesn't tell you what care Mom needs, where she should go, what Medicare covers or what any of it costs. Those answers come from the people who assess her and the people who know her coverage. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've gathered, written down and asked. The care interview walks you through Mom's situation one area at a time, so what you've collected has somewhere to go, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's guide to hospital discharge planning; the rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers